

ANI

me". Today, again, the truism that only Bihar residents can vote in its elections has been granted a certain currency. So, it makes perfect sense, with just three months or so left for the assembly election, to fine-tune quota policies to catch that vibe.

There was indeed some goading. Jan Suraaj Party leader Prashant Kishor had mounted a persistent critique on this front, accusing Nitish of opening Bihar's job market to outsiders in pursuit of national ambitions. RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, too, had recently promised to implement a 100 per cent domicile-based policy should his party form the next government. To head them off, Nitish appears to have stepped into—or at least nodded towards—the long-simmering *bahari-bhitari* (outsider–insider) debate. What better way than to inaugurate this with women, a constituency Nitish has long cultivated. Especially since women are now increasingly seen as decisive in shaping the state's electoral fortunes, with a voting percentage that has consistently outgunned that of male voters by a good country mile over the last decade and a half.

Takeaways

- **The 35 per cent state jobs quota for women is now only for those domiciled in Bihar**
- **This is a tactical nod from Nitish towards the new insider-outsider paradigm**

INSIDER POLITICS

With the latest quota policy, Bihar has joined the ranks of states like Maharashtra and Jharkhand, where the insider-outsider divide has long featured prominently in political discourse. For years, Nitish has carefully distanced himself from the more incendiary rhetoric of his alliance partners, who frequently raised concerns about Bangladeshi infiltrators and invoked the *bahari-bhitari* narrative. While he never openly endorsed such language, this latest move signals a subtle yet significant shift.

By restricting job reservations to domiciled Bihari women, Nitish appears to have crafted his own version of the insider-outsider paradigm—less inflammatory, perhaps, but no less exclusionary. It's a quiet deployment of weaponry he once abjured, now repurposed in the language of administrative reform. In doing so, he has stepped into a narrative he once preferred to observe from the margins. ■

▶ HIMACHAL PRADESH

A DELUGE OF DOUBTS

Flood relief offers political relief for the Himachal CM and his beleaguered party, but its soil is eroding

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

THE FLASH FLOODS ravaging Himachal Pradesh have had a curious corollary. They created an overall optics of solidarity for the Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu regime, which is not an especially solid monolith in the best of times. Handling a major crisis, the CM earned attention with his proactive presence: coordinating relief, seeking central aid, reassuring tourists. He has good reason to try and capture the space from above. Local body elections are slated for later this year, and the ruling Congress has no feet on the ground—literally. Figuratively, it has two left feet. The



TAKING STOCK Himachal CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu at a flooded area, Jul. 9